



Clever Girls La dritte

Director: Mario Amendola

Production Companies: Betauno Film,
Metropolis Film

Screenplay: Mario Amendola

Director of Photography: Sergio Pesce

Editor: Hector Salvi

Art Director: Ivo Battelli

Music: Federico Carducci

Cast:

Sandra Mondaini (*Rina*)

Bice Valori (*Edna*)

Monica Vitti (*Ophelia*)

Franco Fabrizi (*Hamlet*)

Riccardo Garrone (*Lello*)

Paolo Panelli (*Hercules*)

Memmo Carotenuto

Leopoldo Valentini

Gina Amendola

Italy 1958

96 mins

35mm

The screening on Mon 10 Aug will be introduced
by writer Richard Dyer

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Monica Vitti: Creative Force

Clever Girls

In 1950s Rome, three girls use all their wiles to trick their reluctant boyfriends
into marriage. This early and little-seen Vitti film showcases a battle of the
sexes in which only one side will triumph. A female-driven comedy of errors, it
highlights Vitti's nascent star power as she and the other women struggle with
contemporary Italian sexual mores.

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In an early scene from Ettore Scola's Rome-set 1970 comedy *Dramma della
gelosia*, we find a group of five women – flower sellers – sitting together next to
their stalls having lunch. As they eat, the world going by in front of them, they
listen to a record teaching them English phrases. One of the women, Adelaide
(Monica Vitti), says – deadpan – as she makes a few jabs into her pasta: 'My
English pronunciation is better when I'm eating.'

This unaffected image of Vitti as street trader – fingerless gloves, oversized
knitted cardigan, Roman dialect, heartily tucking into food – is a far cry from her
cool, enigmatic performances in the early 1960s work of Michelangelo
Antonioni, the films for which she is still best known, especially outside of Italy.

Boldly challenging conventional cinematic syntax in their depictions of middle-
class ennui, Antonioni's *L'avventura* (1960), *La notte* (1961), *L'eclisse* (1962)
and *Red Desert* (1964) – sometimes referred to as the 'tetralogy of alienation' –
are canonical works in postwar art cinema. They made Vitti an international star
as well as a style icon, 'dethroning Audrey Hepburn and Brigitte Bardot'
according to *Vogue*'s Eugene Walter in 1966.

Born in Rome in 1931, Vitti studied at the city's Academy of Dramatic Arts.
Fully committed to a career in drama, she was told by one of her teachers that
she was equally gifted in comedy. She initially had little ambition to work in film,
aware that the trend in Italy at that time was for films in the neorealist style,
which mostly relied on non-professional actors. In a 1979 *Vogue* interview with
Pierparide Tedeschi, she looked back at her first experiences of film auditions:
'I was told I had an excessively irregular face and was a bit too tall and slim.
One director offered me a role, but on the condition that I changed my facial
features. However, partly because I was afraid of surgery and partly because I
wasn't that interested in the project, I turned it down and went back to the
theatre.'

Her first encounter with Antonioni occurred soon after, when she was hired as
a dubbing artist for the director's 1957 film *Il grido*. It was the start of a
professional and personal partnership that lasted over a decade.

Post-Antonioni, Vitti worked with similarly-renowned filmmakers such as
Joseph Losey on *Modesty Blaise* (1966), Miklós Jancsó on *The Pacifist* (1970)
and Luis Buñuel on *The Phantom of Liberty* (1974), but she became hugely in-
demand for comedies after director Mario Monicelli had the vision to cast her in
his 1968 – mostly UK-set – revenge satire *The Girl with a Pistol*.

Monicelli had already worked with Vitti when she dubbed an actor on his crime
comedy *The Big Deal on Madonna Street* (1958). 'I knew that she was funny
and entertaining, bursting with humour [...],' Monicelli explained in a 1986
interview with Lorenzo Codelli, 'but in film, she hadn't really done many comic

Monica Vitti: Creative Force

Clever Girls Le dritte

Sat 1 Aug 14:50; Mon 10 Aug 20:40 (+ intro by writer Richard Dyer)

Red Desert Il deserto rosso

Sun 2 Aug 12:10; Sat 8 Aug 14:30;
Sun 16 Aug 15:00; Mon 24 Aug 20:40

L'eclisse The Eclipse

Sun 2 Aug 18:10; Sun 9 Aug 15:00 (+ intro by season curator Catherine O'Rawe);
Thu 13 Aug 20:30

Modesty Blaise

Mon 3 Aug 18:00; Sat 22 Aug 14:50

Monica Vitti Season Introduction

Thu 6 Aug 18:10

L'avventura The Adventure

Thu 6 Aug 20:20; Thu 20 Aug 18:00

I Married You for Fun Ti ho sposato per allegria

Sat 8 Aug 12:00; Wed 12 Aug 20:30 (+ intro by writer and researcher Olga Campofreda)

Teresa the Thief Teresa la ladra

Sat 8 Aug 18:00; Tue 18 Aug 20:35

La notte The Night

Sat 8 Aug 20:30; Wed 26 Aug 18:10
(+ pre-recorded intro by Joanna Biggs)

Stardust Polvere di stelle

Sun 9 Aug 17:50 (+ intro by season curator Catherine O'Rawe); Tue 18 Aug 18:00

Tosca La Tosca

Tue 11 Aug 18:10; Sat 29 Aug 12:20

The Oberwald Mystery Il mistero di Oberwald

Fri 14 Aug 18:10; Sat 29 Aug 18:00

The Girl with a Pistol La ragazza con la pistola

Wed 19 Aug 18:10; Sat 29 Aug 20:55

I Know That You Know That I Know

Io so che tu sai che io so

Thu 20 Aug 20:45; Mon 31 Aug 12:00

Secret Scandal Scandalo segreto

Mon 24 Aug 18:30; Thu 27 Aug 20:45

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roles. This was mostly down to the short-sightedness of producers who couldn't see past her work with Antonioni.'

In *The Girl with a Pistol*, Vitti plays a young Sicilian woman who pursues a former lover from Sicily to the UK, to avenge her honour. Filming locations for the picture, which co-starred Stanley Baker, included Edinburgh, Sheffield and Bath.

Several dazzling comic performances followed, perhaps most impressively, in Dino Risi's episode film *That's How We Women Are* (1971), where Vitti takes on 12 separate roles. In one segment – a gentle parody of Antonioni in its use of modernist architecture, its air of mystery and lack of dialogue – Vitti plays a lone character clad in a long black trenchcoat and black leather gloves who's seen transporting a large case across town on foot.

In 1980, Vitti was reunited with Antonioni for Jean Cocteau adaptation *The Mystery of Oberwald*, the first film by the director to be shot on video. During the rest of the decade, Vitti continued to be active in film and TV. In 1990, she made her directorial debut with a screenplay co-written by her partner (and later husband) Roberto Russo. *Secret Scandal* featured Vitti and Elliott Gould as Margherita and Tony, a middle-aged married couple whose relationship comes under strain when Margherita brings a video camera into their home. 'In my life the camera has looked at me more than my mother has,' Vitti told *The Guardian's* John Vidal. 'But the camera I can never talk to, it never answers. In the film, the camera is dangerous because it is a witness. It takes everything, has many faces. A camera, you know, once you are conscious of it, changes everything.'

Vitti's final film credit came a couple of years later, and around the same time she also wrote the autobiographical volumes *Seven Skirts* (1993) and *A Bed Is Like a Rose* (1995), both of which showcased her characteristic warmth, humility and playfulness as well as an uncommonly acute appreciation of her craft.

Pasquale Iannone, *Sight and Sound*, April 2022